

TONGAEDIT

The South Pacific island of Tonga is a great destination for the southern winter season as everything is on, including whale watching, diving and lots more. This week we're talking about Tonga, the beautiful island in the Pacific Ocean. And I have with me Owen Powell who's with Tourism Tonga.

Owen, welcome to the program. Hello, and thank you. We're here to promote Tonga, of course the best destination in the Pacific, so we're hoping that we get more people to visit Tonga in the next few months.

And tell us about the island, Owen. It's a beautiful place and how many people are there for people who've never been there or don't know anything about it? Well, Tonga is in the South Pacific. It's about five hours on the plane from Melbourne, about two and a half hours from Auckland.

It's a very cool, average temperature. This time is about 27, 26. The peak time for tourists in Tonga is between June and October.

The temperature out there is about 23, 24. It's really comfortable and that's the tri-season. Also, during that time, that's the whale season in Tonga.

It's a very popular activity for tourists, swimming with whales and taking photos with whales. And having such a temperate, all year round temperature, it's so comfortable, isn't it? And the people there are very welcoming of outsiders. Well, we're also known as a friendly island and it's the people there.

I think it's our greatest asset, it's our people. They treat visitors with special regards. We have something over and above the other Pacific nations.

We are very welcoming to visitors and I think it's a good thing for us. And it's tremendous the amount of things you can do on Tonga. You have a big range of activities from the nature to diving to all sorts of things.

That's correct. We have fishing, Marlin, Mahimahi and Yellowfin tuna for fishing. A lot of fishermen from Australia and New Zealand come to Tonga just for big game fishing.

Diving is another popular activity in Tonga. The water is so beautiful, so clear and you can dive anywhere. In the island of Fea where there's a lot of underwater cave there and you go up to the vital, the water is beautiful and clear along Tonga Tapu coast.

It's also beautiful. Snorkeling is another popular activity. The tropical fish, a wide variety of tropical fish is available in Tonga, beautiful colours.

Now Owen Powell from Tourism Tonga, tell us a bit about your couple of favourite things to do that you'd highly recommend to tourists there. Again, as I say, during whale season swimming with whales is a popular activity and it's really, really good. A lot of operators from Tonga Tapu to Vavau, they offer a variety of activities including swimming with whales, taking photos while swimming with whales.

For me another activity is visiting heritage site. There are sites dated back 500-600 years ago that have been marked and recognised as a historical site for Tonga. Some of the stone hatch in Tonga transported 200-300 miles from a different island to Tonga to make up all this.

And these are really ancient, aren't they? That's amazing. They are still there. The locals are still looking after them and we want to share with everyone else.

To say the least, Tonga is a very enthusiastic sporting nation and your rugby teams there are very, very strong. I think the talent in Tonga is enormous. Every kid in Tonga can play rugby.

As you can see, our rugby team, our league team, you can see the world championship champion in Tiscus. He's got a Tongan heritage there. We are into our sport and whatever we do we want to do, give it all our best.

How can people find out more about Tonga online, if they want to do that? Online, if you go to www.tongaholiday.com or www.kingdomoftonga.com There is a website there and you can get more information about Tonga and it gives you links to other airlines and accommodations and other tourist operators. Owen Powell from Tourism Tonga, thank you very much for being with us on the programme this week. Thank you for having us on the air and I would like to see more tourists visit us in Tonga.